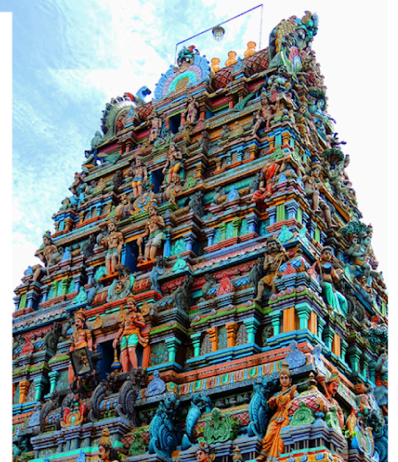


General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Indian Sculpture and Pottery



INDIAN SCULPTURE AND POTTERY



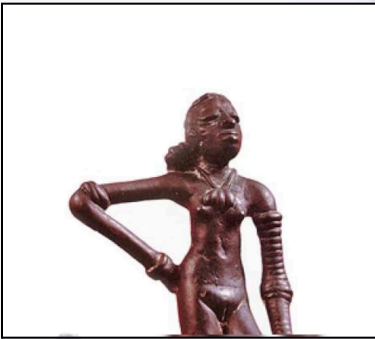
Indian Sculpture

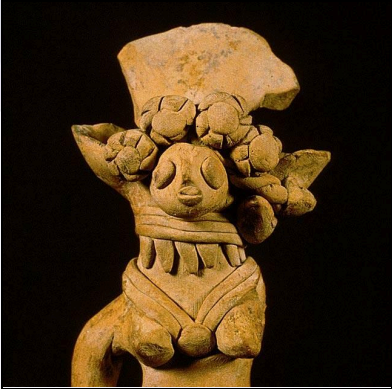
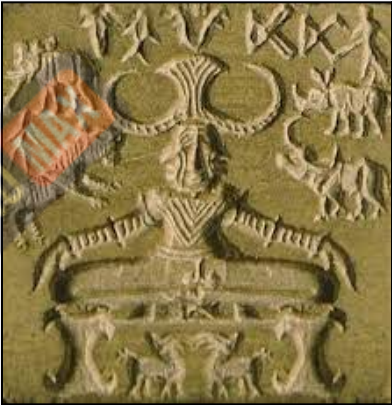
The tradition of **Indian sculpture** extends from the **Indus Valley Civilization** (2500-1800 BCE) to the present day, reflecting cultural, religious, and social changes throughout history. Indian sculpture has evolved over time, integrating **regional, stylistic, and foreign influences**, while retaining a **linear and graceful character**.

Features of Indian Sculpture

- **Indus Valley Sculpture** – Unique terracotta and metal figurines, emphasizing simplicity and volume.
- **Vedic and Mauryan Sculpture** – Early sculptures were rural; Mauryan sculpture reflected **Buddhist influence**, with **stone pillars and stupas**.
- **Gupta Sculpture** – Known for **cave temples**, e.g., **Ajanta and Ellora**, representing **grace and symbolism**.
- **South Indian Sculpture** – Chalukya and Pallava sculptures introduced new forms, combining **northern and southern traditions**.
- **Chola Sculpture** – Famous for **bronze statues** depicting rhythmic movements, e.g., **Nataraja**.
- **Medieval Sculpture** – Influence of **Persian and Indo-Islamic elements**, such as calligraphy, **minarets, and arches**.
- **Modern Sculpture** – Shift towards **installations** and **modern forms**, continuing to express versatility and creativity.

Indus Valley Civilization Sculpture (2500-1800 BCE)

Sculpture Type	Sculpture	Image
Metal Sculptures	Lost-wax process used for bronze casting. Example: Dancing Girl from Mohenjodaro, with bangles and a relaxed posture.	
	Humped bull and buffalo figurines were also found.	
Stone Sculptures	Bearded Man statue, made from steatite, represents a priest or king.	
	Red stone male torso found in Harappa.	

Terracotta Art	Mother Goddess figurines symbolize fertility .	
	Seals depict animals, deities, and human figures, including the Pashupati Seal .	

Mauryan Empire Sculpture (321-185 BCE)

Sculpture Type	Sculpture	Image
Stupa Sculpture	The Sanchi Stupa features elaborate gateways (toranas) with Buddhist motifs.	

Pillar Sculptures	Ashoka's Lion Capital at Sarnath, made of sandstone, symbolizes royal authority. Pillars inscribed with Dhamma principles spread Buddhist teachings.	
Figurine Sculptures	Yakshi figurines	
	Elephant sculpture at Dhauri.	

Post-Mauryan Sculpture (200 BCE - 300 CE)

- **Gandhara School:**
 - Influenced by **Greek, Roman, and Persian styles**, with depictions of **Buddha** in black stone.
 - Known for elaborate **drapery** and **wavy hair**.
- **Mathura School:**
 - Depicts **strong figures** with simple attire; uses **red sandstone**.
 - Produced images of **Jain Tirthankaras** and **Hindu deities**.
- **Amaravati School:**
 - Known for **white marble sculptures** and **Buddha depictions**.

Gupta Empire Sculpture (4th-5th Century CE)

- **Characteristics:**
 - Soft, pliant body forms with **intricate halos** around the Buddha figures.
 - Use of **red sandstone** and emphasis on **graceful, elegant poses**.
 - Famous for **terracotta art** representing deities like Shiva and Parvati.

Medieval Indian Sculpture (8th-13th Century)

- **Chalukya Sculptures:**
 - **Badami, Aihole, and Pattadakal temples** exhibit a fusion of **Dravidian and Nagara styles**.
- **Hoysala Sculptures:**
 - Rich carvings with **erotic themes**, as seen in **Halebidu and Belur temples**.
- **Rashtrakuta Sculptures:**
 - **Ellora and Elephanta Caves** showcase **rock-cut temples** with intricate carvings.

Indo-Islamic and Mughal Sculpture (13th-18th Century)

- **Delhi Sultanate:**
 - Introduced **arches, domes, and enamelled tiles**.
 - **Terracotta art** remained popular.
- **Mughal Sculpture:**
 - Emphasized **calligraphy, pietra dura inlay, and foliage patterns**.
 - Iconic structures include the **Taj Mahal** and **Red Fort**.

Modern Indian Sculpture (20th Century - Present)

- **Colonial Influence:**
 - Adoption of **European styles** with Indian themes, known as **Indo-European art**.
- **Key Sculptors:**
 - **Ram Kinker Baij, Fanindranath Bose, D.P. Roy Chowdhury**.
- **Contemporary Sculpture:**
 - Focus on **installations** and **realism**, reflecting social and cultural themes.

Table: Indian Sculptural Traditions and Styles

Period	Sculptural School/Tradition	Key Features	Notable Examples
Indus Valley Civilization	Terracotta and Metal Art	Lost-wax process; animal and human figurines	Dancing Girl, Pashupati Seal
Mauryan Empire	Stone Pillars and Stupas	Sandstone pillars with inscriptions	Sanchi Stupa, Ashoka's Lion Capital
Gandhara School	Graeco-Buddhist Art	Greystone, drapery, Greek influences	Buddha images from Taxila
Mathura School	Red Sandstone Sculptures	Strong figures, simple attire	Jain Tirthankaras, Padmapani Buddha
Amaravati School	Marble Sculptures	White marble, crowded scenes	Dharma Chakra from Lingaraja Palli
Gupta Empire	Elegant and Graceful Art	Intricate halos, pliant body forms	Buddha statues from Sarnath
Delhi Sultanate	Indo-Islamic Art	Domes, pointed arches, terracotta art	Qutub Minar, Alai Darwaza
Mughal Empire	Pietra Dura and Calligraphy	Marble inlay, foliage motifs	Taj Mahal, Red Fort
Chalukya Dynasty	Rock-Cut and Structural Temples	Soapstone, Nagara-Dravidian fusion	Badami and Aihole Temples
Hoysala Dynasty	Intricate Erotic Carvings	Decorative sculptures with Hindu themes	Belur and Halebidu Temples
Rashtrakuta Dynasty	Rock-Cut Temples	Massive monolithic statues, cave temples	Ellora and Elephanta Caves

Modern Indian Sculpture	Realism and Installations	Contemporary themes, Indo-European fusion	Ram Kinker Baij's sculptures
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Indian Pottery

Pottery is one of the **oldest and most iconic art forms** in India, with a history that dates back to the **Indus Valley Civilization** and even earlier settlements. This cultural craft has evolved over millennia, reflecting **changing social, economic, and environmental conditions**. Pottery not only holds artistic value but also aids **archaeologists and historians** in **reconstructing ancient civilizations** and **deciphering non-script cultures**. Today, pottery continues to be an integral part of Indian art and culture.

Neolithic Age (10000 BCE)

- Pottery first appears during the **Neolithic period**, marking the **beginning of human settlement**.
- Early pottery was **handmade**, though later evidence suggests the use of a **foot-wheel** for shaping vessels.

Chalcolithic Age (4500-2000 BCE)

- Pottery styles became more **diverse**, with distinct **ceramic cultures** emerging.
- Examples of pottery from this period include:
 - **Black and Red Ware (BRW)**
 - **Black-on-red ware**
 - **Ochre-colored pottery (OCP)**

Indus Valley Civilization (3300-1500 BCE)

- Pottery evolved to exhibit **refined craftsmanship** and included **polished and decorated wares**.
- Key pottery types from this period:
 - **Rough-surface pottery**
 - **Harappan burial pottery**
 - **Ochre-colored pottery (OCP)**
 - **Black-grey burnished ware**

- **Black-on-red ware**
- **Grey-ware and Painted Grey Ware (PGW)**

Vedic Age (1500-500 BCE)

- Pottery reflected the **ritual and social life** of the time.
- Prominent pottery types:
 - **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)**
 - **Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)**
 - **Megalithic pottery** from Kerala.

Mauryan Period (321-185 BCE)

- The **pottery wheel** became widely used during this era, resulting in more **uniform and refined ceramics**.
- **Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)** was the most advanced type, popular during both the **pre-Mauryan** and **early Mauryan periods**.

Kushana Period (1st to 4th Century AD)

- A new phase of pottery emerged during the **Kushana period**, with notable advances in **Bengal and North India**.
- Characteristics of Kushana pottery:
 - **Red Polished Ware (RPW)** with **stamped designs**.
 - Large quantities of **dull and bright redware**.

Gupta Period (4th and 5th Century AD)

- Gupta pottery showcases exceptional **ceramic craftsmanship**, with key sites such as **Ahichchhatra, Rajgarh, Hastinapur, and Bashar** yielding important pottery evidence.
- **Redware** was the most characteristic pottery of this era.

Turko-Mughal and Rajput Period (12th Century AD onwards)

- During the **Turkish rule**, **Persian and Central Asian potters** were invited to settle in northern India, bringing with them new pottery techniques.

- Key developments in this period:
 - **Glazed ceramics** featuring **Persian models with Indian motifs**, popular in **Gujarat and Maharashtra**.
 - **Blue pottery** became a hallmark of **Jaipur**, gaining fame as a **traditional craft**.

Notable Types of Indian Pottery

Period	Type of Pottery	Key Features
Chalcolithic Age	Black and Red Ware (BRW)	Simple design, dual-tone surfaces.
Indus Valley Civilization	Polished Ware, Harappan Pottery	Polished surfaces, burial pottery.
Vedic Age	Painted Grey Ware (PGW)	Painted with geometric motifs.
Mauryan Period	Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)	Smooth, glossy finish with fine craftsmanship.
Kushana Period	Red Polished Ware (RPW)	Stamped designs; bright red surfaces.
Gupta Period	Redware	Predominantly red, with simple shapes and forms.
Turko-Mughal Period	Glazed Pottery	Persian motifs, vibrant colours, and glazed surfaces.
Modern Era (Rajput Period)	Blue Pottery (Jaipur)	Iconic blue and white designs.

Key Sites of Pottery in India

Site/Region	Period	Pottery Type
Mehrgarh	Pre-Indus Valley	Early handmade pottery.
Harappa	Indus Valley Civilization	Burial pottery, Ochre-colored pottery (OCP).

Hastinapur	Gupta Period	Redware pottery.
Jaipur	Mughal and Rajput Period	Blue pottery with Persian influence.
Kerala	Vedic Period	Megalithic pottery.
Gujarat	Turko-Mughal Period	Glazed ceramics with Indian and Persian motifs.
Bengal	Kushana Period	Red polished ware with stamped designs.